



SCIENCE SPHERE · A PARENT'S GUIDE

Is Your Child's Tutor Actually Working?

THE 11 SIGNS OF REAL PROGRESS
AND THE **RED FLAGS** MOST PARENTS MISS.

A free 3-minute read for parents of GCSE & A-Level students

The problem most parents don't see

You're paying for tutoring. Your child says "it was fine." The tutor sends "great session today!" And you're left hoping the next mock results will tell you whether it's working.

By then, it's usually too late.

A tutor can be kind, patient, likeable and still be ineffective. The two aren't the same. Here's how to tell the difference, before exam day.



6 signs your tutor is actually working

- **Your child can teach the topic back.** - Ask them to explain what they learned. A well-taught child gives a rough but real explanation. A poorly-taught one recites a formula they can't define.
- **There's structured work between sessions.** - Specific tasks, then checked next lesson. "Just do some past papers" isn't a plan.
- **Mistakes get diagnosed, not just corrected.** - Strong tutors ask "why did you go down that path?" then target the specific gap next session.
- **You can see a plan.** — Within 2–3 sessions your tutor should be able to tell you what they're working on and why. "Just whatever they need" is a problem.
- **Confidence is grounded, not hollow.** - Your child stops saying "I can't do this" and starts attempting hard questions even when unsure. That shift matters more than any test score.
- **Independent results start moving.** - Within 6–12 weeks, school work done without the tutor present should be visibly improving. That's the one that counts.



SCIENCE SPHERE
ONLINE TUTORING

5 red flags most parents miss

- **Every session is reactive.** - If sessions are spent purely on this week's homework, that's a paid homework companion — not a tutor.
- **Feedback is always generic.** - “Great session!” with no detail means the tutor isn't paying attention — or isn't willing to be honest about gaps.
- **No diagnostic in the first 2 sessions.** - Jumping straight into topics without understanding the student first means teaching blind.
- **Praise outpaces challenge.** - Ambitious students need “that'd lose you 2 marks - here's why,” not empty applause.
- **No reference to mark schemes or exam technique.** - Within a year of exams, your tutor should be regularly talking about method marks and examiner expectations.

Spotting 2 or more?

Don't fire your tutor on the spot. Ask them this:

“What's the plan for the next 6 weeks, and which specific weaknesses are you targeting?”

A good tutor welcomes the question. A weak one gets defensive. That tells you everything.



SCIENCE SPHERE
ONLINE TUTORING

What fair pricing looks like

- **£15–£25/hr** - University students on marketplaces. Quality varies wildly. Fine for confidence-building, rarely grade-changing.
- **£30–£45/hr** - Where serious tutoring starts. Prepared sessions, mark schemes, a clear plan. Best value lives here.
- **£50–£70+/hr** - Ex-examiners and premium agencies. Rarely necessary unless you have specialist needs (Oxbridge, STEP) or are extremely time-pressured.

Why the cheapest option usually costs more

A £20/hr tutor who needs 30 sessions to lift a grade costs £600. A £40/hr tutor who does it in 15 also costs £600 — and saves 15 weeks of your child's time.

A cheap tutor who never moves the needle is infinitely expensive. Every pound is wasted because the result never arrives.

Don't ask "what's the hourly rate?"
Ask "what's the cost per grade boost?"



Your one-page checklist

Run through this once a month. Print it, screenshot it, fridge it.

GOOD SIGNS - want most of these

- ✓ Your child can explain concepts in their own words
- ✓ Specific work set between sessions, then checked
- ✓ Mistakes get diagnosed, not just corrected
- ✓ There's a clear plan you can ask about
- ✓ They attempt harder questions without flinching
- ✓ Independent school work is improving
- ✓ Tutor talks about mark schemes and exam technique

WARNING SIGNS - 2 or more means time for a conversation

- ✗ Every session is just this week's homework
- ✗ Feedback is always generic
- ✗ No diagnostic in the first 2–3 sessions
- ✗ Every answer gets praise regardless of quality
- ✗ No reference to mark schemes
- ✗ Your child can't tell you what they worked on yesterday
- ✗ 6+ weeks in with no movement in independent work

Three questions to ask this week

1. **To your child:** "What's one thing you understand now that you didn't a month ago?"
2. **To your tutor:** "What are the top two weaknesses you're currently working on?"
3. **To yourself:** "Is my child's independent work - not their tutor-supervised work - actually getting better?"



SCIENCE SPHERE
ONLINE TUTORING

One final thought

Tutoring done well teaches a student how to learn, how to attempt difficult problems without panic, and how to take responsibility for their own progress. That compounds long after the exam.

Tutoring done badly is worse than no tutoring, it builds false confidence and displaces real study.

The difference is rarely about qualifications or hourly rate. It's about whether the tutor is teaching, or just sitting next to your child for an hour a week.

Use the signals. Ask the questions. Trust your instinct when something feels off, it usually is.

About Sphere Science

Online tutoring in Maths and Physics for ambitious GCSE and A-Level students. What makes us different: lessons are delivered by someone who recently sat these exams, so the perspective comes from what current papers actually feel like, not how the syllabus looked twenty years ago.

One-to-one. Online. Weekday evenings and weekends. If you'd like a no-pressure chat about whether tutoring could help your child, get in touch.

**BOOK WITH
US NOW!**